

LFB HOLDINGS

Decision Distortion Assessment Reports

BASE REPORT

Your Decision Distortion Assessment — Accumulation Is Your Dominant Force

Your assessment is in. Of the four forces that bend organizational judgment under pressure, accumulation is showing up most actively in your company right now. It's the quietest of the four forces — and typically the last one an organization recognizes in itself, because every individual decision that produced it looked reasonable when it was made.

Of the four forces — noise, bias, accumulation, and incentive misalignment — accumulation is the only one that operates across decisions rather than within them. Noise distorts individual judgment calls. Bias bends the direction of individual calls. Incentives govern how fast either compounds. Accumulation is different: no single decision has to go wrong for it to take hold. What it requires is simply that addition keeps winning over subtraction, decision after decision, until the aggregate weight of individually-defensible choices has made the next decision harder than it needs to be.

What accumulation is

Accumulation is what happens when organizations have a deeply ingrained, largely invisible default toward addition — adding features, processes, hires, metrics, and strategic priorities when faced with a problem — while systematically overlooking subtraction as an equally valid path forward.

This isn't a preference. It's a cognitive accessibility failure: additive options come to mind first, readily and automatically. Subtractive options require deliberate generation, and under pressure, deliberate generation is exactly what's in short supply. The pull operates at three reinforcing levels. Cognitively, addition is simply more accessible — it surfaces first. Culturally, accumulation looks like action; subtraction leaves no visible trace. And economically, the incentive structures of venture-backed companies reward what gets built and launched, not what gets wisely stopped or removed.

Each individual addition — a feature, a process, a hire — seems reasonable in isolation. The problem only becomes visible in aggregate. And by the time it does, the aggregate has made the next decision harder: more variables, more stakeholders, more weight resisting clarity.

How it typically shows up

Facing a new competitor, a Series C company launches two new product modules, attacks both enterprise and SMB simultaneously, and spins up four parallel pilots. The KPI dashboard swells to fifteen metrics. Decision rights blur. Coordination meetings triple while capital spreads thin. From outside, it looks like scaling execution issues. From inside, every one of those decisions felt justified — the modules addressed real gaps, the market expansion was based on real signals, the pilots were tracking real opportunities. What none of those individual decisions accounted for was what all of them together had created: a company that had outrun its own ability to steer.

The hardest part of accumulation is that no single decision was wrong. The aggregate was the problem. And the aggregate was invisible until the speed dropped and the burn rose.

Where your assessment is pointing most clearly within accumulation is on strategic symmetry — whether your organization's planning conversations treat addition and subtraction as genuinely equivalent options. The question your assessment flagged is structural: not whether subtraction ever happens, but whether it enters the room with the same standing as addition. In most strategic planning processes, it doesn't. The agenda organizes around what to build, where to expand, what to invest in. What to stop, exit, or simplify is addressed — if at all — as a secondary conversation, after the additive directions have been established. By that point, the cognitive bandwidth for subtraction has already been spent, and the cultural weight of visible action has already tilted the room. The organizations that do this well treat subtraction as a first-order agenda item, not a closing note — and find that the quality of their additive decisions improves as a result, because the additions that survive a genuine subtraction conversation are the ones that actually deserve the resources.

Where to start

The first intervention is to put subtraction first on the strategic planning agenda — not last, not after additions have been established. Every planning conversation opens with one question: what should we stop, exit, or simplify before we discuss anything we might add? This isn't about finding things to cut for the sake of cutting. It's about giving subtraction the cognitive bandwidth it needs to compete, which it will never have if it arrives after the room has already spent an hour building the additive case.

The second is a subtraction quota with teeth. Require every team to identify and commit to one thing it will stop doing before any resource request for something new is considered. Not suggested — required, and evaluated with the same rigor as the additions. The quota isn't the goal; the discipline is. An organization that can name one thing per quarter it has deliberately stopped is an organization that has broken the default. One that can't is one where accumulation is still running unopposed.

The research behind this

The academic foundation for what your assessment detected comes primarily from *Subtract: The Untapped Science of Less* by Leidy Klotz — the most direct account of addition default and why subtractive options systematically fail to surface when organizations are under pressure to improve. The finding that's most directly applicable to your situation: even when adding and subtracting require identical effort, people still overwhelmingly default to addition. The default isn't about convenience. It's cognitive, cultural, and economic simultaneously — which is why it takes a structural intervention to counteract it.

What's next

The full Decision Distortion whitepaper from LFB Holdings walks through how accumulation combines with the other three forces — noise, bias, and incentive misalignment — and how to locate the specific points in your decision process where a single closed gap would have the greatest effect.

If you'd like to talk through what your results mean for your company specifically, we're glad to do that.

LFB Holdings: lfbholdings.com

For ongoing case-by-case analysis of how these forces operate in real organizational decisions, Bad Call is a subscription brief that applies this framework to actual decision sequences — company autopsies, one at a time.

Bad Call: badcall.ai